

Editorial

Dear Readers,

Oracle has taken over Sun Microsystems.

Can't think of any other development that could beat this news, in terms of its sheer impact on the Open Source world. This one is really big! And with so many possible eventualities, many of which will give open source enthusiasts the goose bumps. We decided to do a major story on this development for our next issue (June 09), in order to explore every possible implication of this mega merger.

The question that topped our list was what would happen to MySQL, which Sun had recently acquired for a whopping US\$ 1 billion? Many had feared for MySQL's long-term prospects after Sun's acquisition—but the lure of reaching out to enterprise customers through Sun's sales team seemed to offset the threats. Now, we are talking about the biggest proprietary database firm acquiring the fastest growing open source database project—*that's* tricky. We did ask a few experts for their opinion on the subject, and got mixed views. Some believe that MySQL is now too strong to be killed, and hence Oracle would be smart enough to use it and expand its base in new markets, while others believe it might try to slow down MySQL's growth so that it does not end up competing with Oracle's own database.

What about OpenOffice.org? Will Oracle use it to create problems for Microsoft on MS Office turf? After all, Larry Ellison, Oracle's big boss, has been quite open about his anti-Microsoft sentiments, and this could be a good chance for him. Plus, OpenOffice.org also powers the Symphony project of another of Oracle's competitors—IBM. How closely will the two teams work, I wonder.

Red Hat, too, could have some serious competition now. Earlier, Oracle was selling Red Hat's Enterprise Linux (RHEL) minus the Red Hat trademarks. Now Oracle has access to the entire Solaris stack, and if it combines the strength of Solaris and Linux, and leverages its sales army—we could have a serious battle. Noting that this will only

result in even more options for customers, Jim Zemlin of the Linux Foundation has gone public in stating that it's 'good news' for the Linux ecosystem.

Then there's Java too, which was also open sourced by Sun. Ellison is beaming with pride about this acquisition. His famous quote about Java says it all, "...the most important software Oracle has ever acquired". So, there's nothing to worry about here. But, if you are connected with other Sun-sponsored Open Source projects such as NetBeans and GlassFish, there're reasons for concern. Almost everyone believes that Oracle will slash Sun's R&D budget, and if that happens, these projects might get disbanded.

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In a nutshell—Linux has seemingly got a boost. Java's future is certain. The fate of NetBeans and GlassFish is threatened, and that of MySQL and OpenOffice.org is anyone's guess.

Best Wishes!



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